Media bank for Moodle
Use walk-through

For teachers. Step by step, with pictures. Upload a file once, then use it in as many courses as you like.

What you will learn

1. Put a picture, video, audio file or PDF in the Content bank.
2. Add it to your course.
3. Change the file later, and undo the change.
4. Add a description, transcript and captions.

It takes about 20 minutes.

Moodle 5.0 to 5.3. The pictures come from Moodle 5.3, so your screens may look a little different, but the buttons have the same names.

Before you begin

The **Media bank** is a part of Moodle called the **Content bank**. Think of it as a shelf for your files. You put a file on the shelf **once**. Then any course can use it.

The big idea: link or copy

When you add a bank file to a course you choose one of two things:

Link to the file	The course points at the file on the shelf. If you swap the file on the shelf later, **the course gets the new one by itself**.
Make a copy of the file	The course gets its own separate file. It **never changes**, even if the file on the shelf is swapped.

> **Tip. If you are not sure, keep Link.** It is already selected for you.

What you need

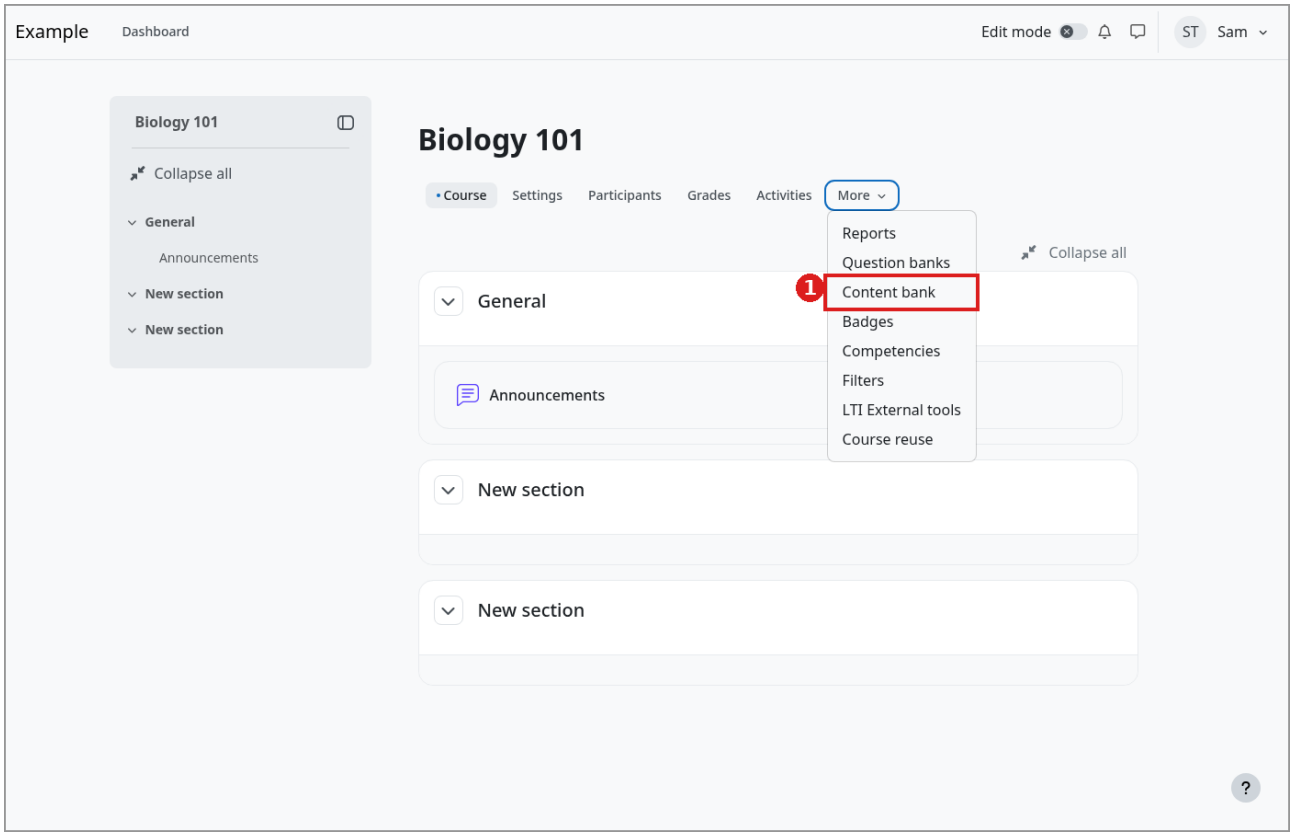
- A Moodle login that lets you **edit a course** (a teacher).
- A file to try: a **picture** (png, jpg, gif, webp), a **video** (mp4, webm), an **audio file** (mp3, m4a, ogg) or a **PDF**.
- Your site decides how big a file may be. If your file is refused for being too big, ask your Moodle administrator.

> **Tip.** Red boxes with numbers in the pictures show where to click. The number matches the number in the text.

Part 1: Put a file in the Content bank

1 Open the Content bank

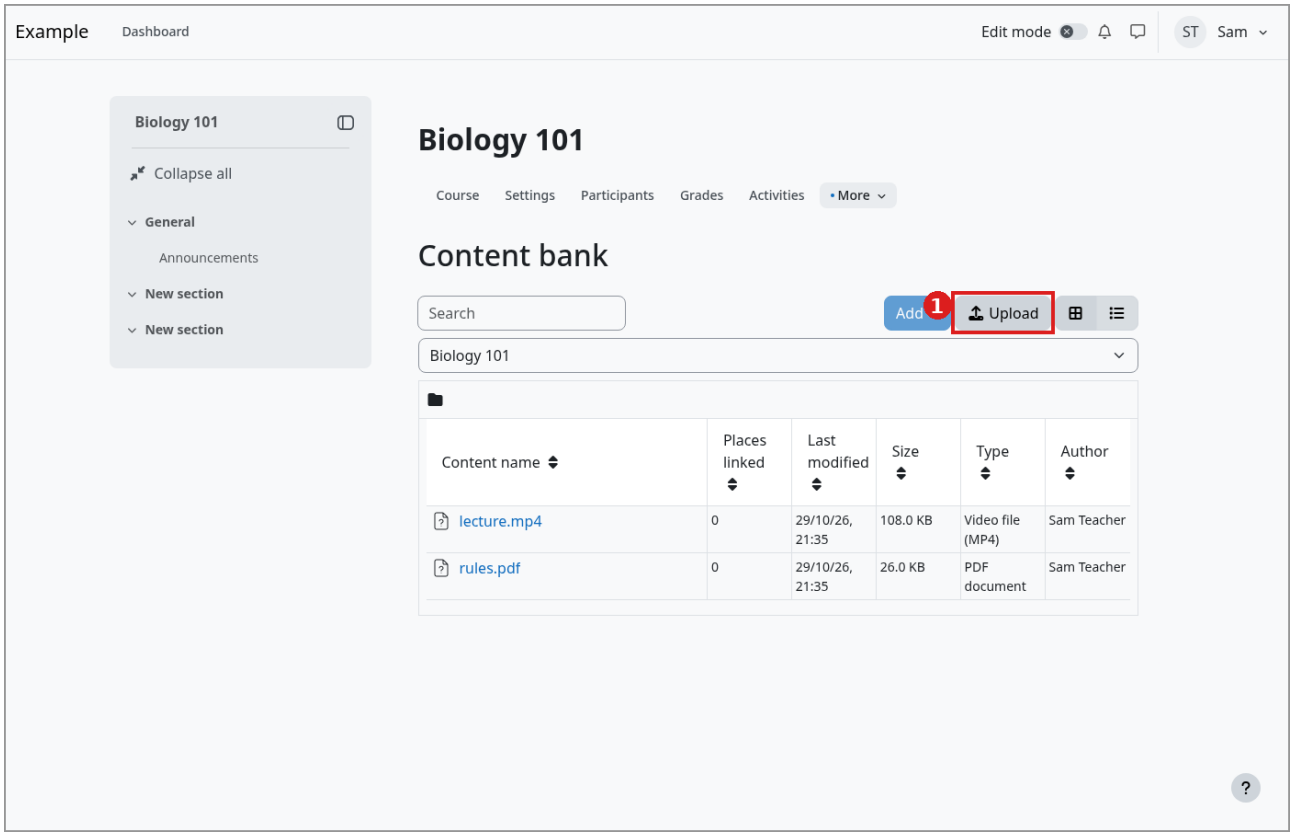
Open your course. In the menu under the course name, click **More**, then click **Content bank** (red box 1).



The "More" menu in your course.

2 Click Upload

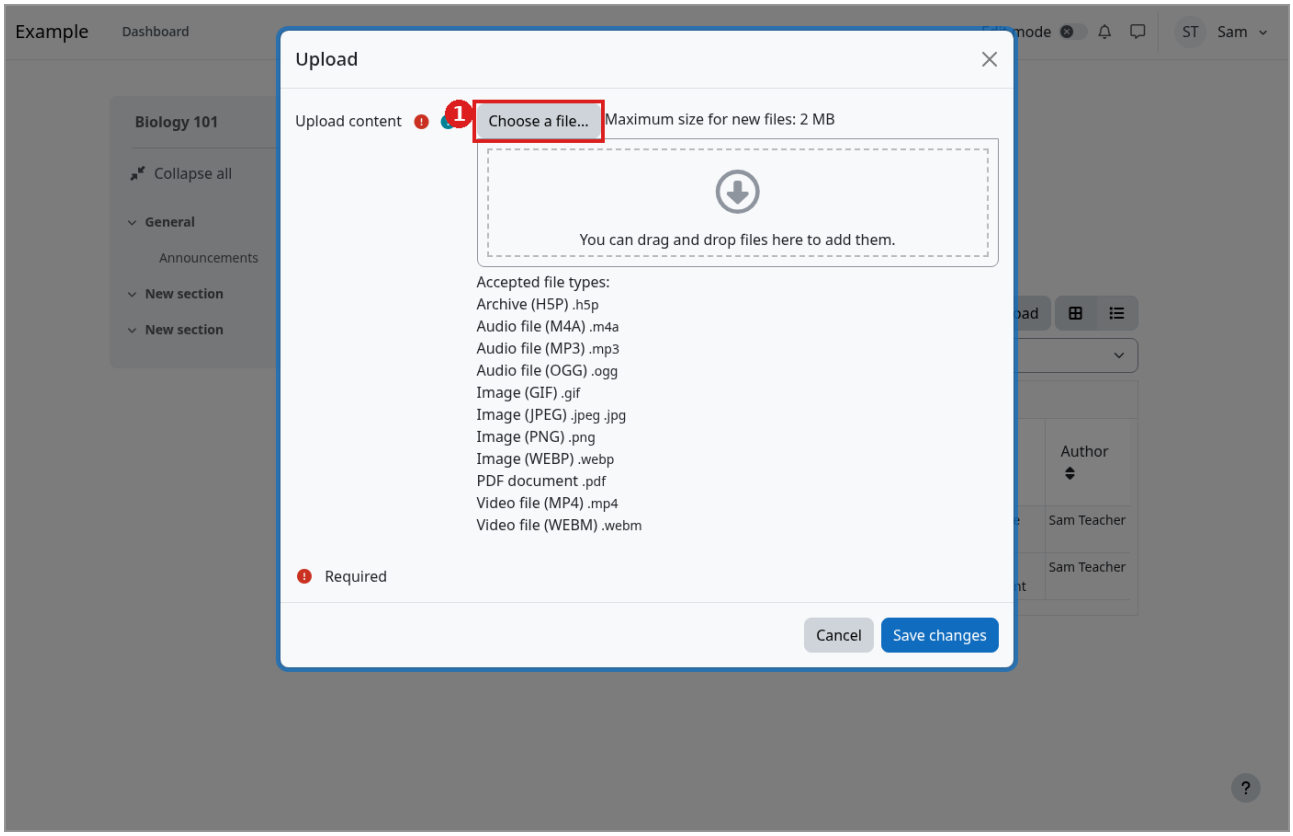
The Content bank lists the files for your course. Click **Upload** (red box 1).



The Content bank page.

3 Choose a file

A box called **Upload** opens. Click **Choose a file...** (red box 1).

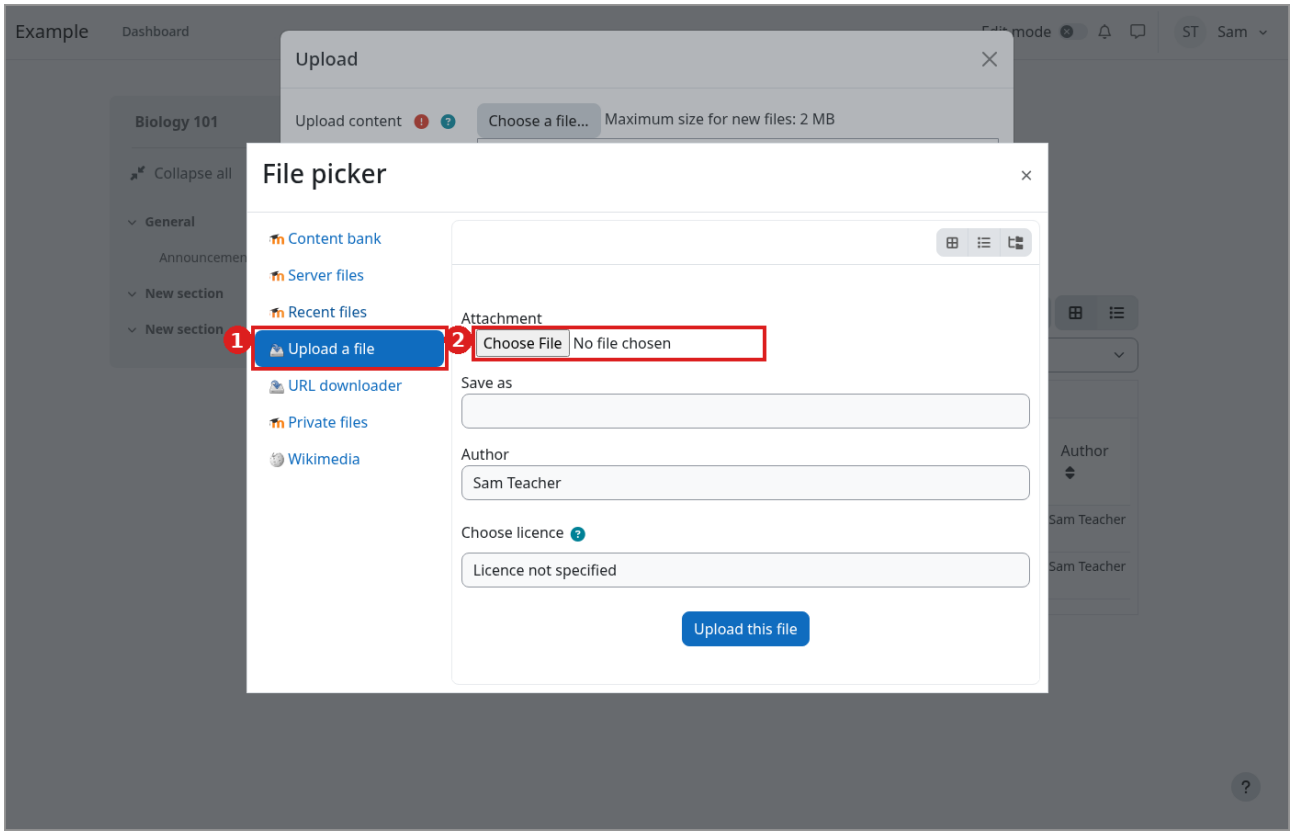


The Upload box.

4 Pick "Upload a file"

A second box, the **File picker**, opens. On the left click **Upload a file** (red box 1). Then click **Choose File** (red box 2). Your computer opens its own window: find your file, click it, and click **Open**.

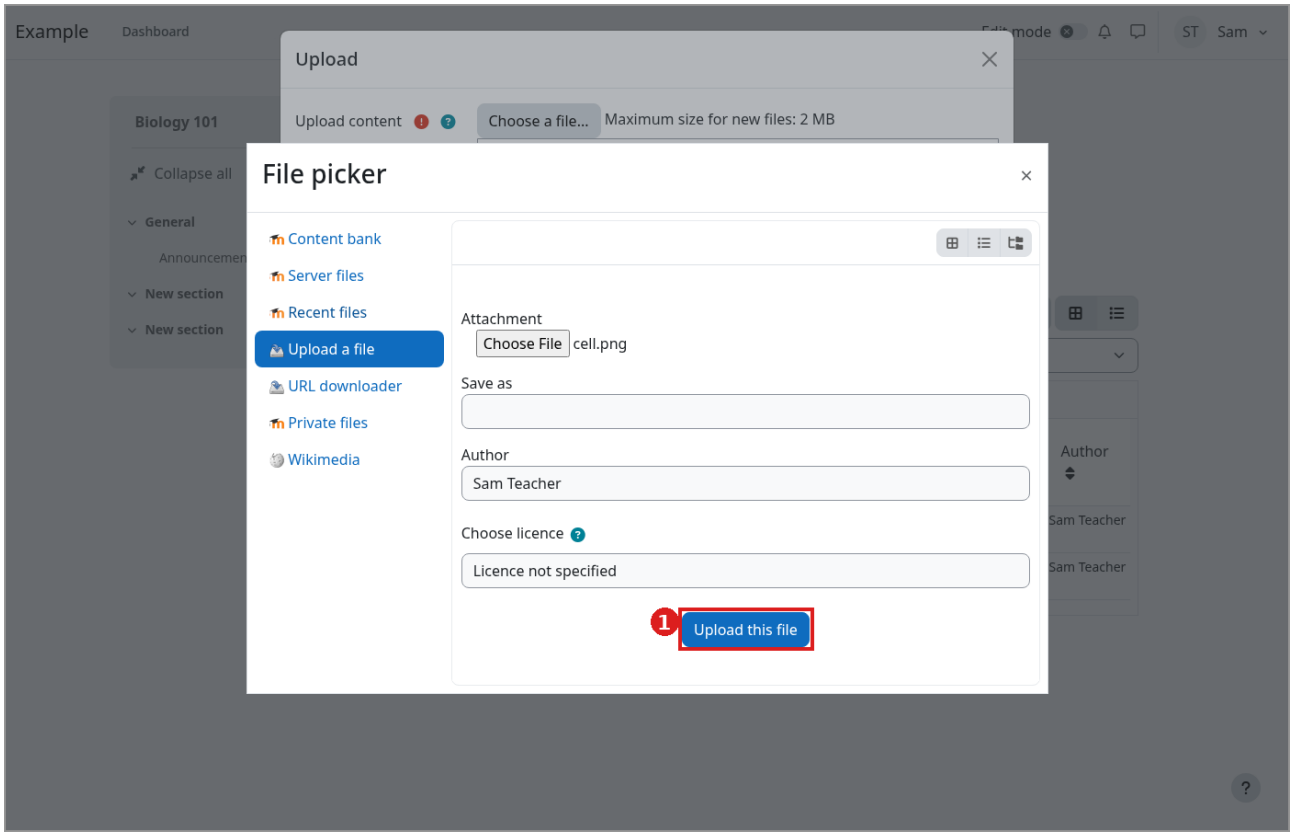
That window belongs to your computer, so it looks different on Windows, Mac and Linux. It is not shown here.



Click "Upload a file", then "Choose File".

5 Upload it

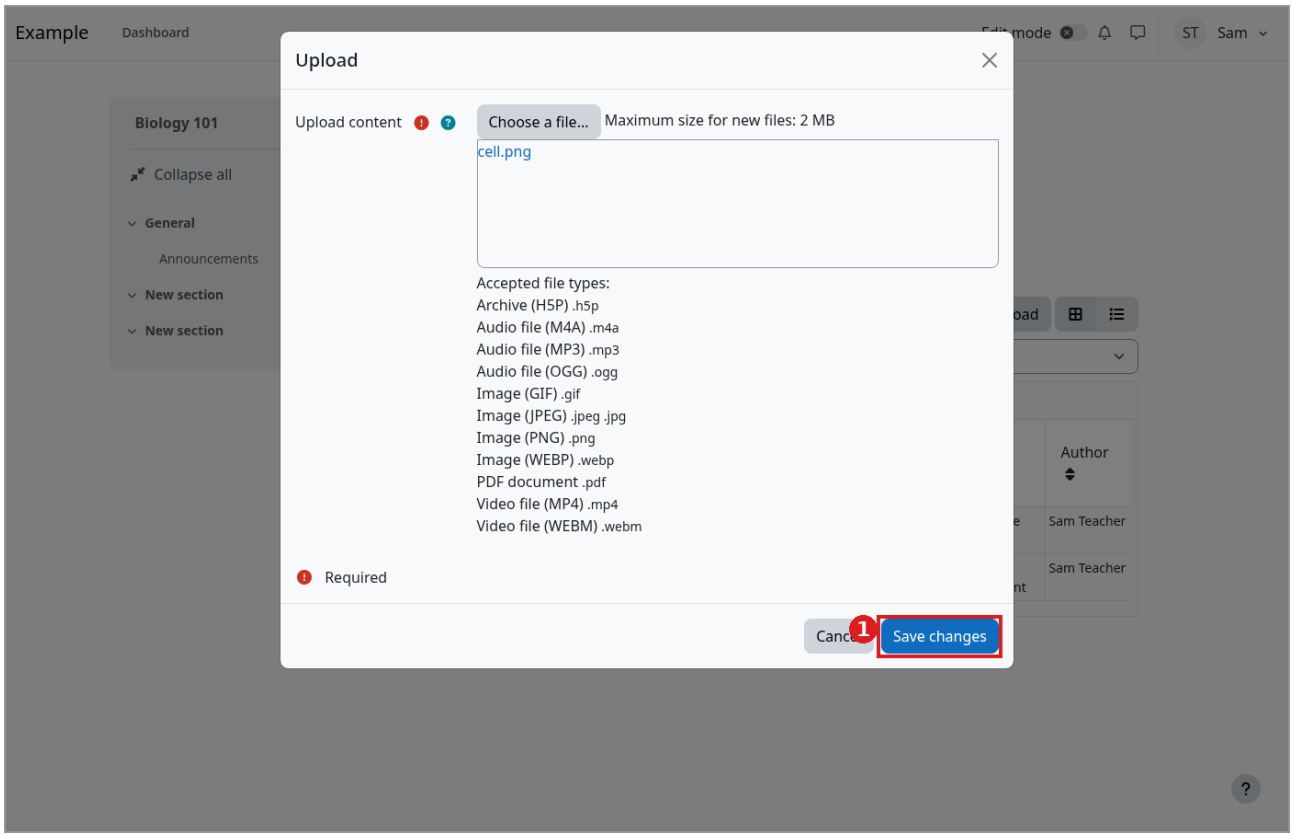
The file name now shows next to the button. Click **Upload this file** (red box 1).



Click "Upload this file".

6 Save

The File picker closes and your file name is in the box. Click **Save changes** (red box 1).

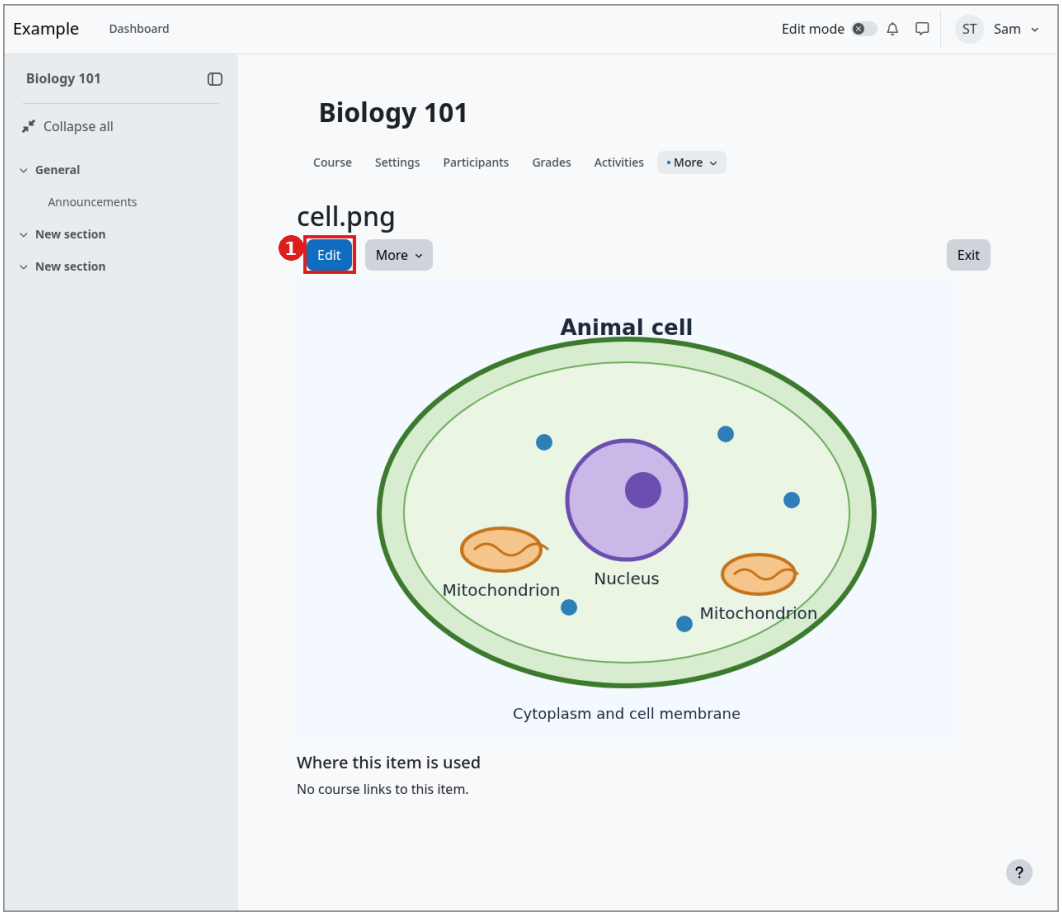


Click "Save changes".

7 Your file is in the bank

Your file opens on its own page. You can see it (or play it). The page also has the buttons **Edit** (red box 1), **More** and **Exit**, and a section **Where this item is used**.

A video that is an MP4 is prepared in the background for faster playback. You do not need to do anything.

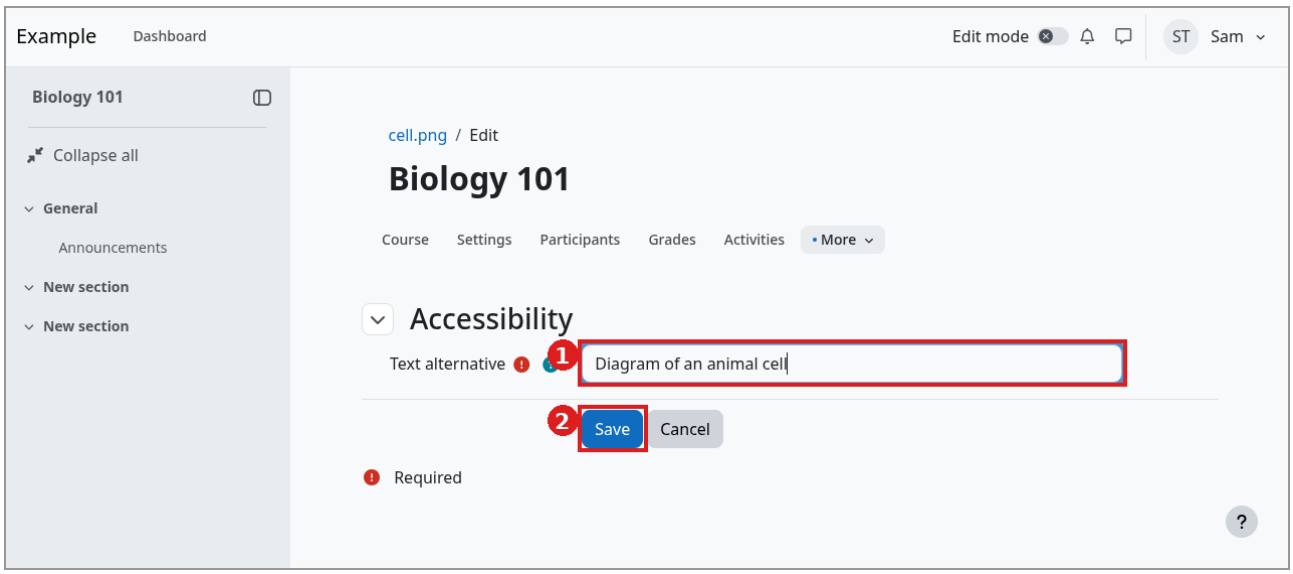


The page of your uploaded file (an "item").

8 Describe a picture

Every **picture** needs a short description for people who cannot see it. Click **Edit**. Type the description in **Text alternative** (red box 1). Then click **Save** (red box 2).

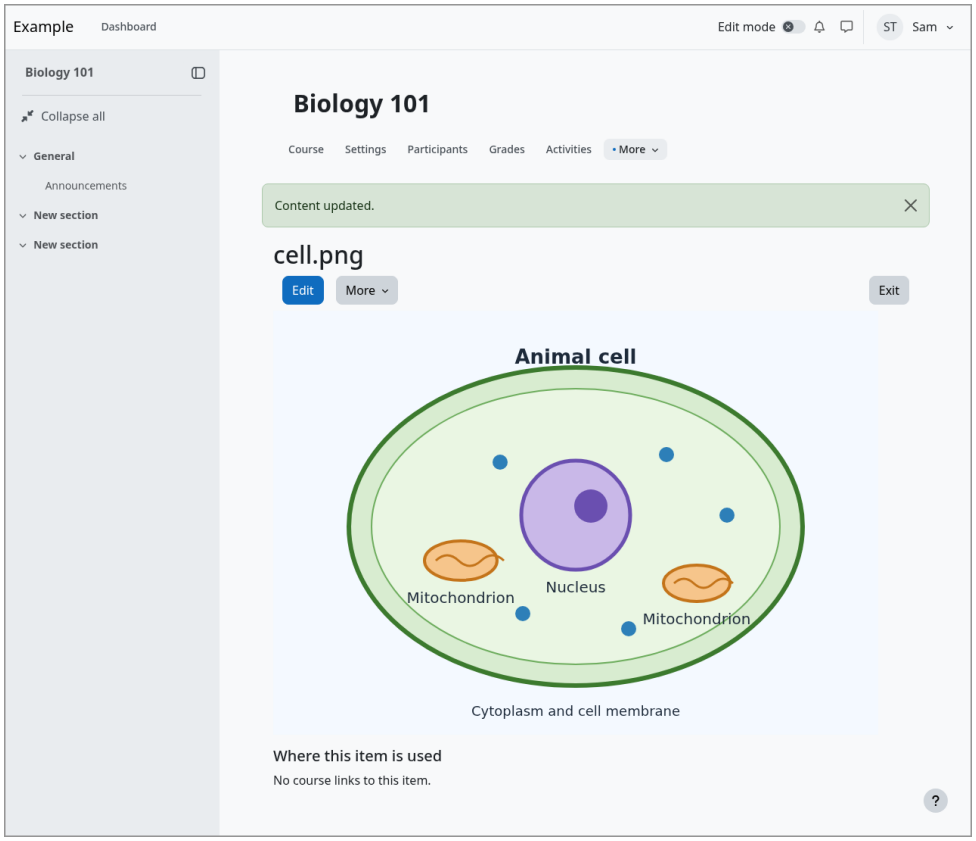
> **Tip.** Say what the picture shows, in one short sentence. For example: *Diagram of an animal cell*. Moodle does not let you save a picture without it.



Type the description, then click "Save".

9 Saved

You see **Content updated** in green. Your file is ready to use.



The green message says it worked.

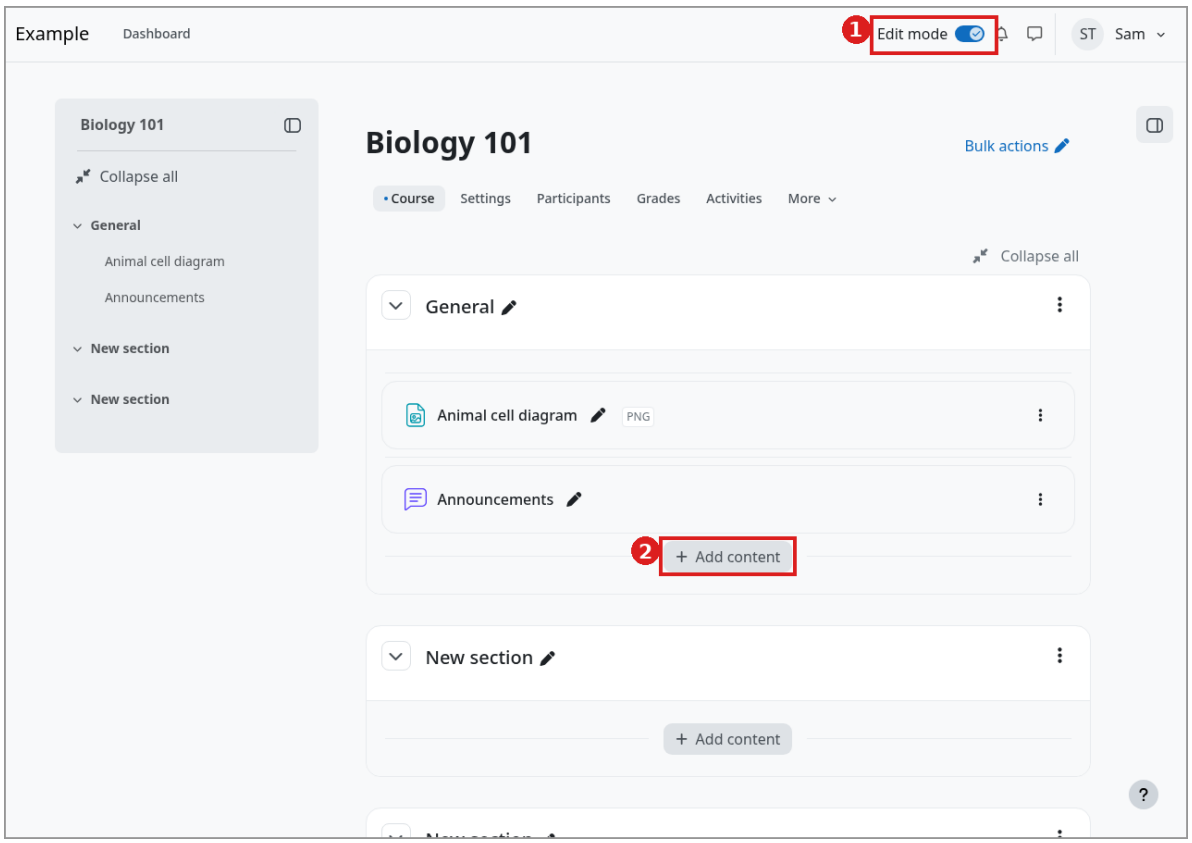
Part 2: Use the file in your course

The example adds a **File** to the course page.

10 Turn editing on

Open your course page. Switch **Edit mode** on, at the top right (red box 1). Click **Add content** in the section where you want the file (red box 2).

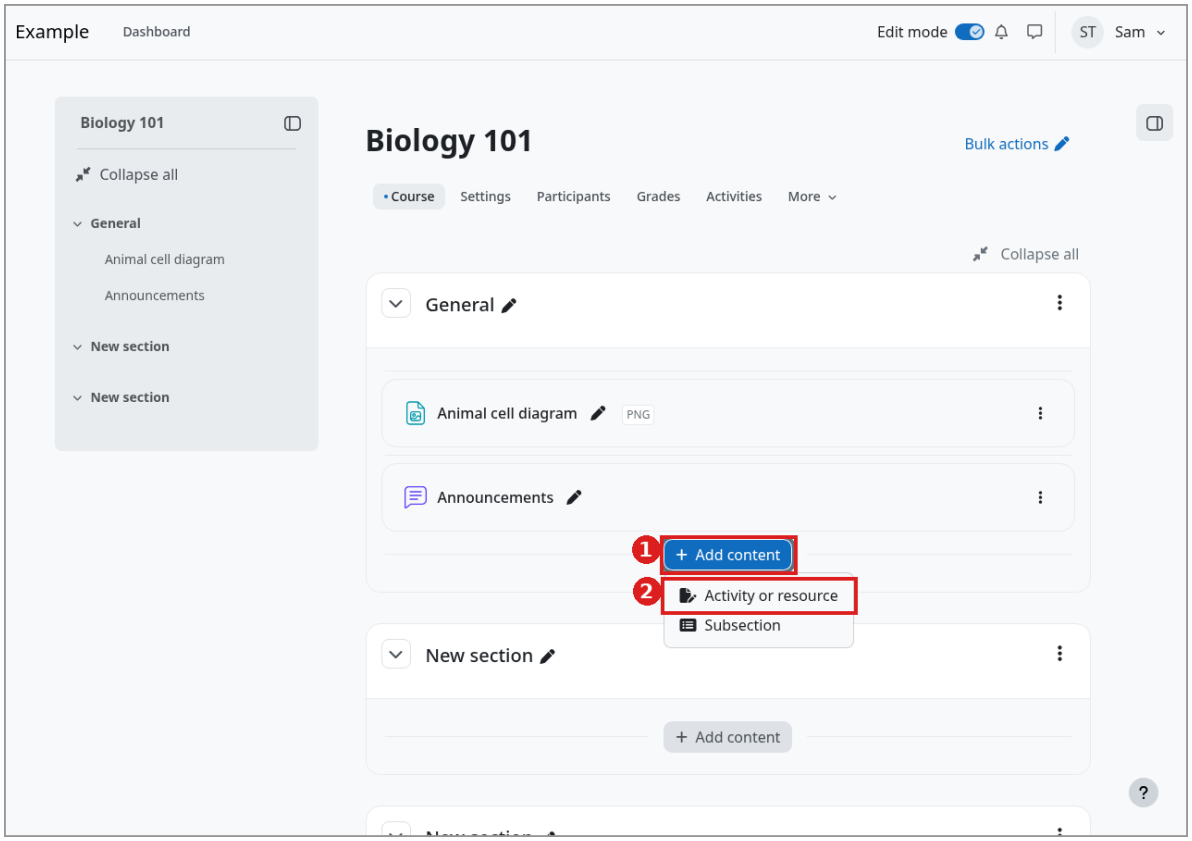
> **Tip.** Your course page will look different from this one. Use the section you want.



Edit mode is on. Click "Add content".

11 Choose "Activity or resource"

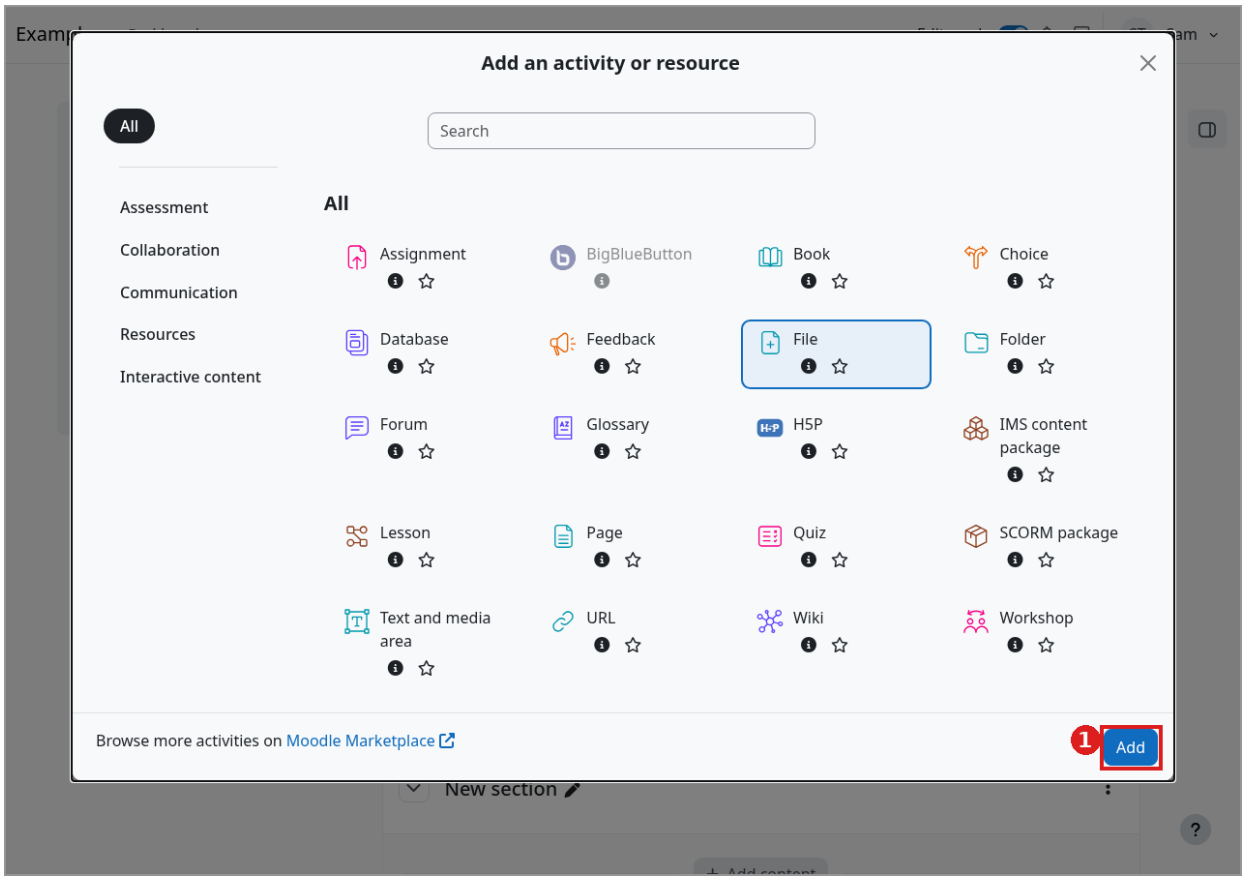
A small menu opens. Click **Activity or resource** (red box 2).



The Add content menu.

12 Choose "File"

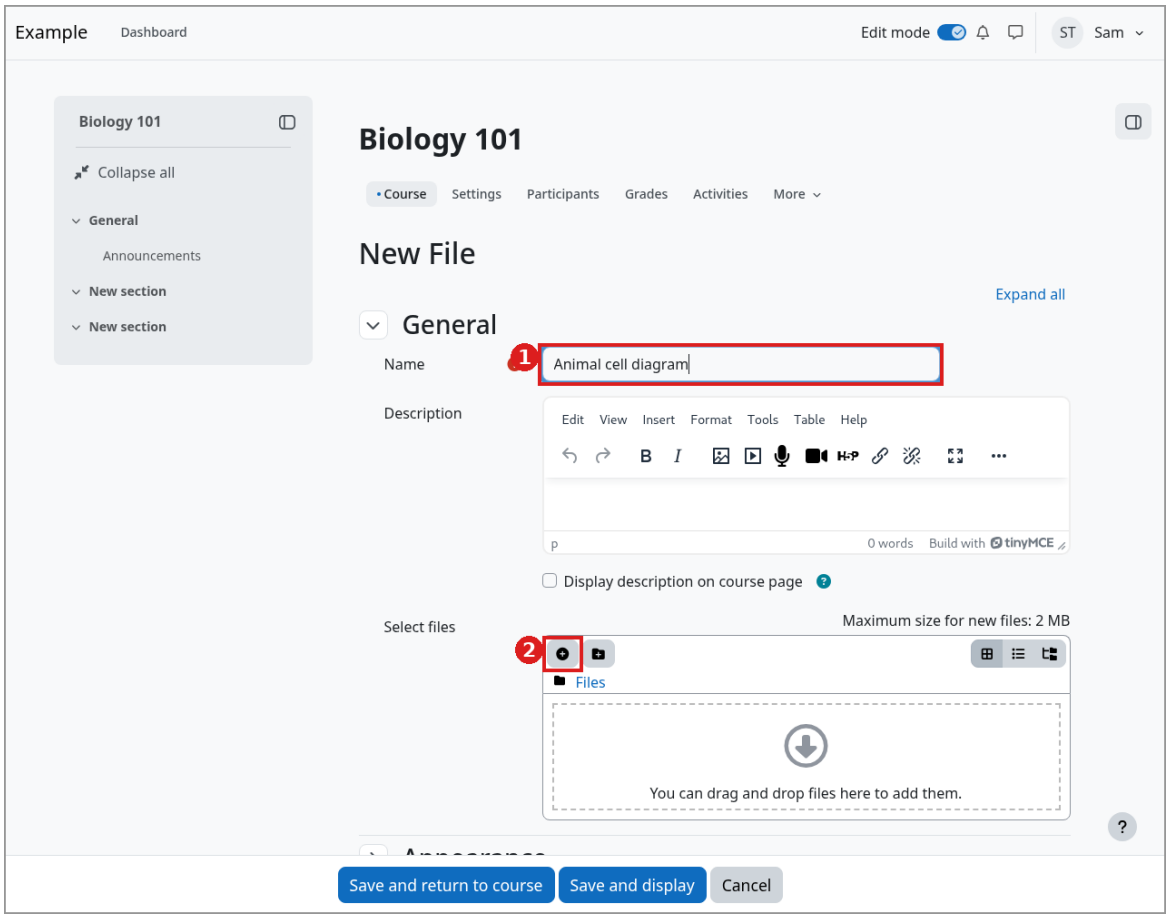
A window shows many kinds of activity. Click **File** (it turns blue), then click **Add** (red box 1).



Click "File", then "Add".

13 Name it and add the file

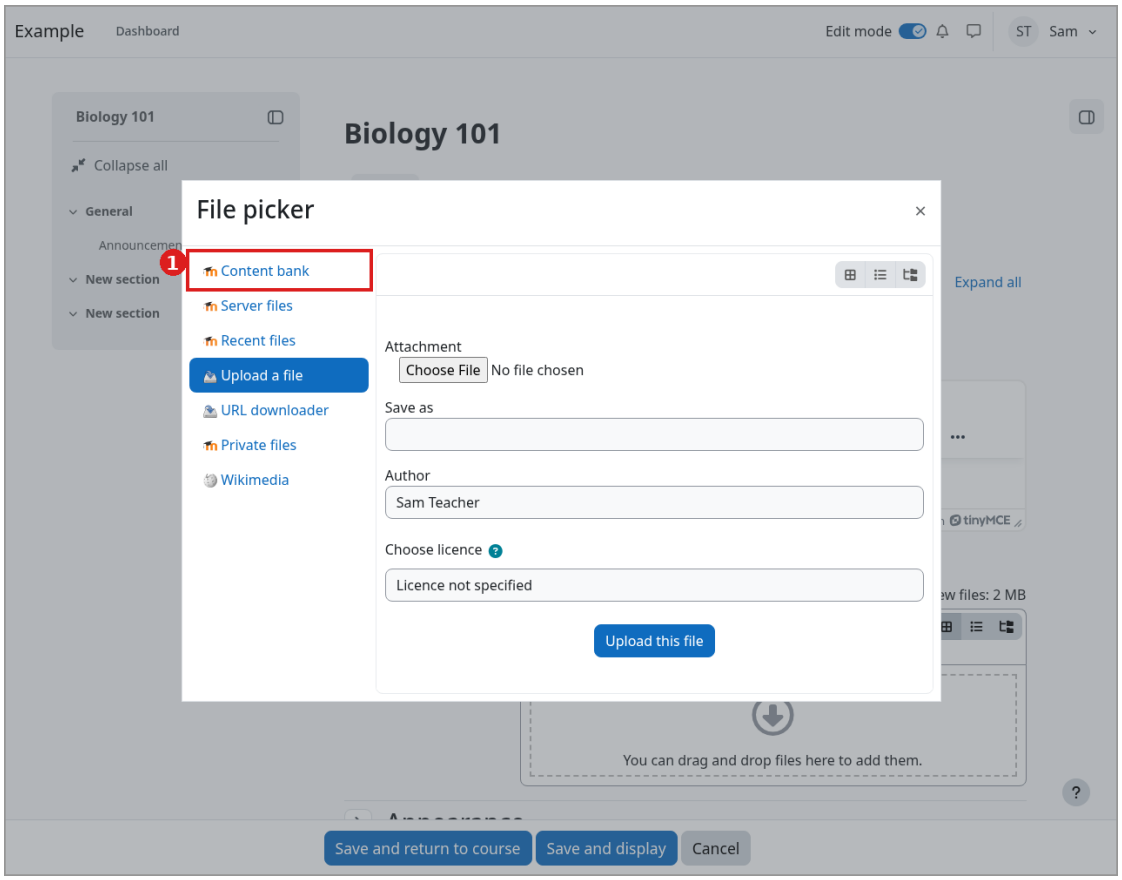
Type a **Name** that students will see (red box 1). Under **Select files**, click the round **Add...** button with the plus sign (red box 2).



Give it a name, then click the plus button.

14 Pick "Content bank"

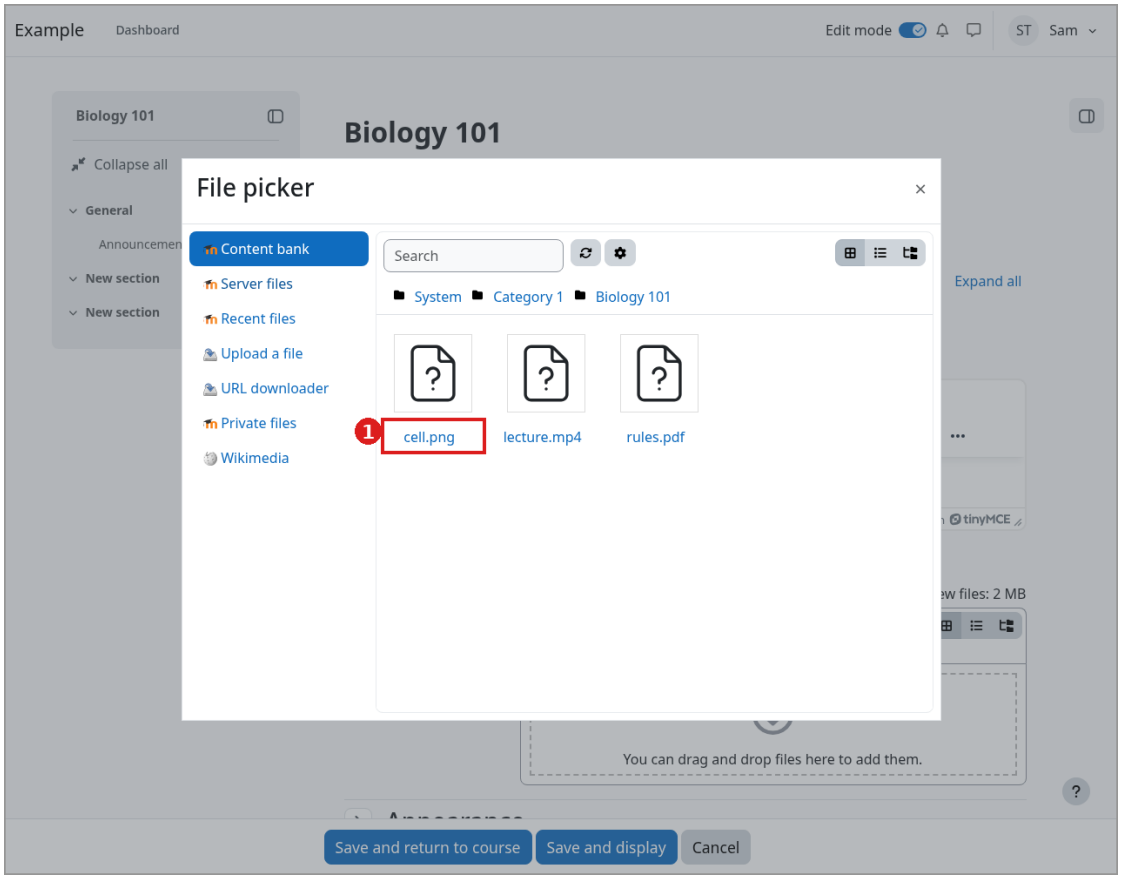
The File picker opens. On the left click **Content bank** (red box 1). The list of your bank files appears.



Click "Content bank" on the left.

15 Click your file

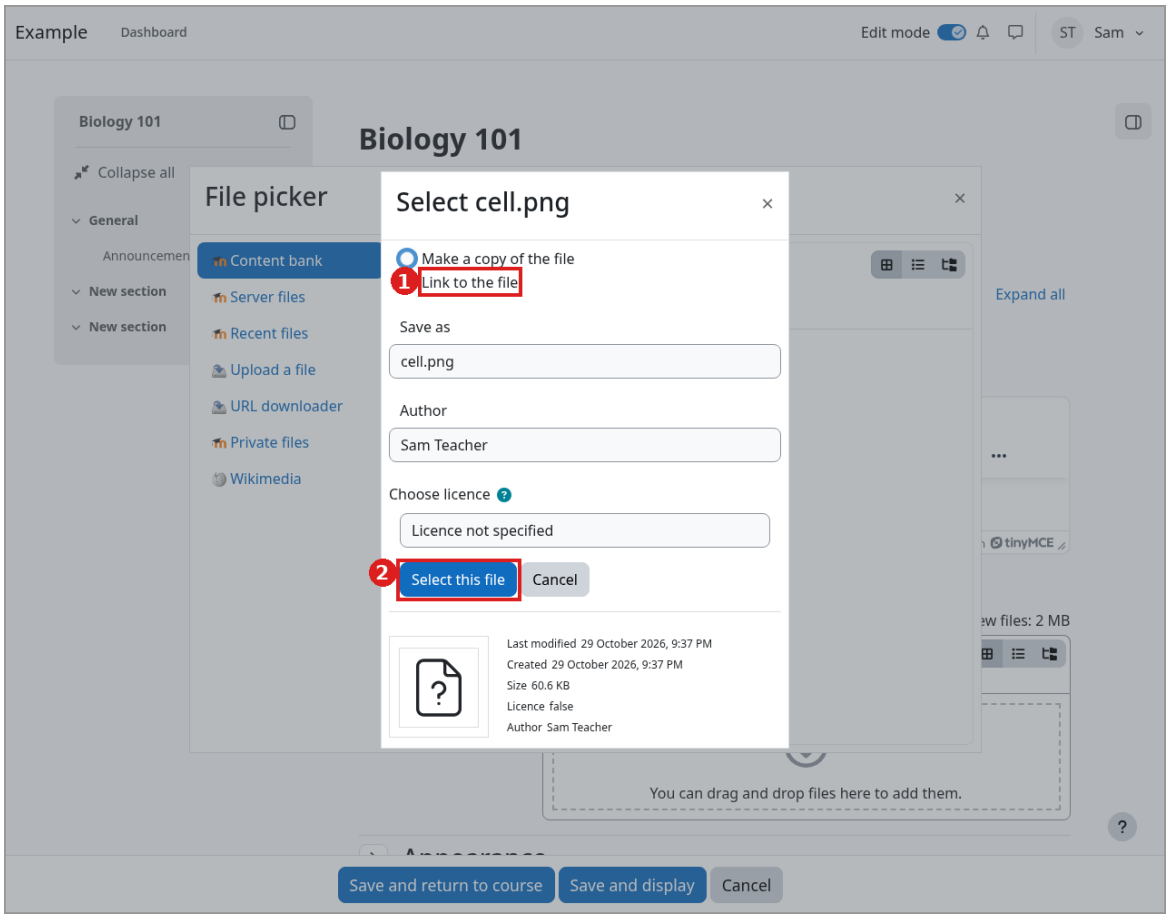
Click the file you want (red box 1). Here it is **cell.png**.



Your bank files. Click the one you want.

16 Link or copy?

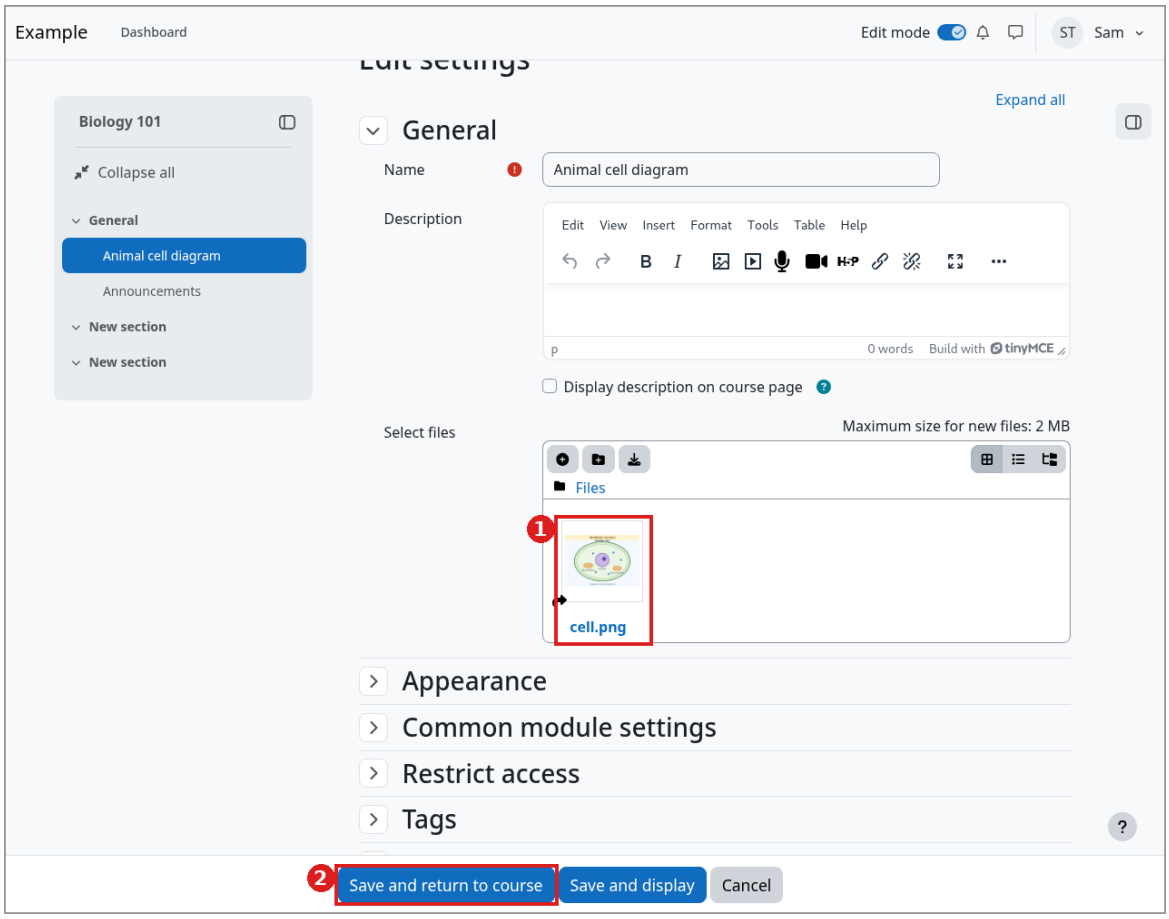
A box asks how to use the file. **Link to the file** is already chosen (red box 1). **Leave it as it is** unless you want a copy that never changes. Click **Select this file** (red box 2).



Keep "Link to the file", then click "Select this file".

17 Save

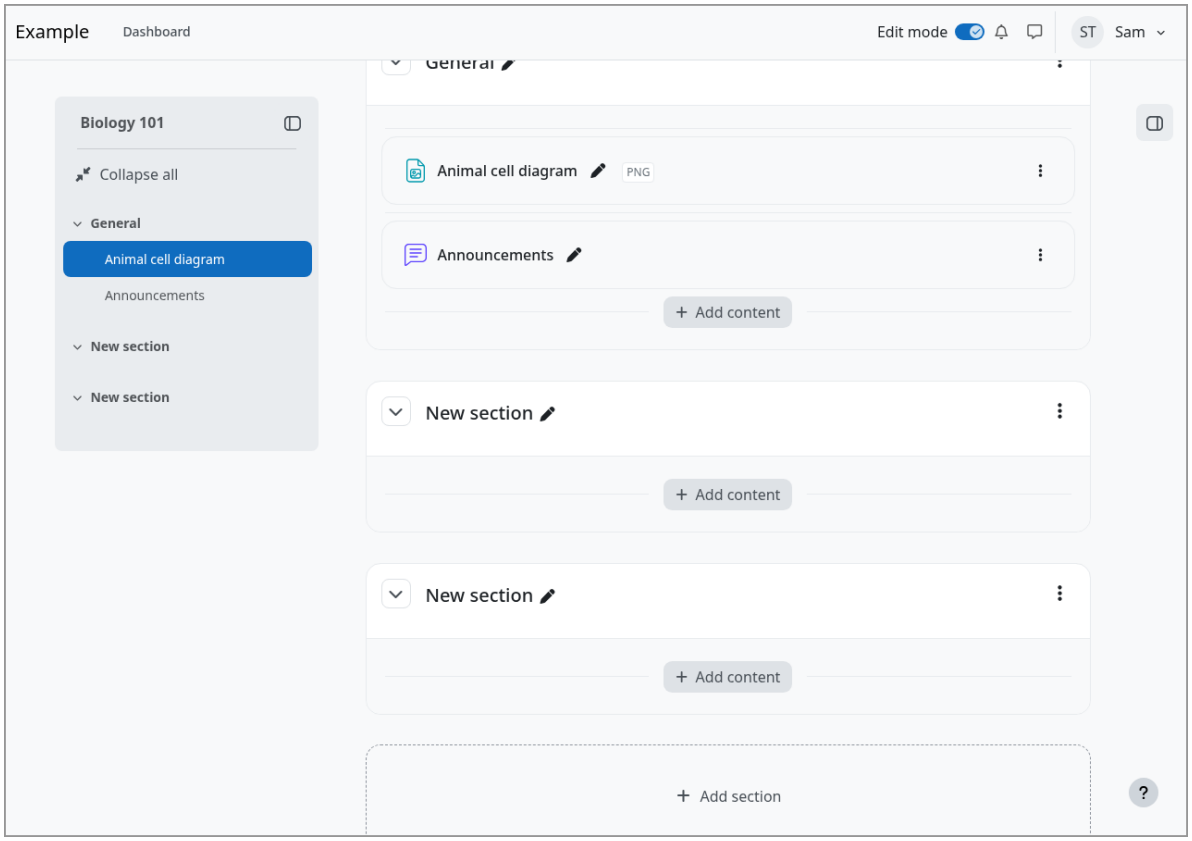
The file is now in the **Select files** box (red box 1). The little arrow on it shows that it is a **link**. Click **Save and return to course** (red box 2).



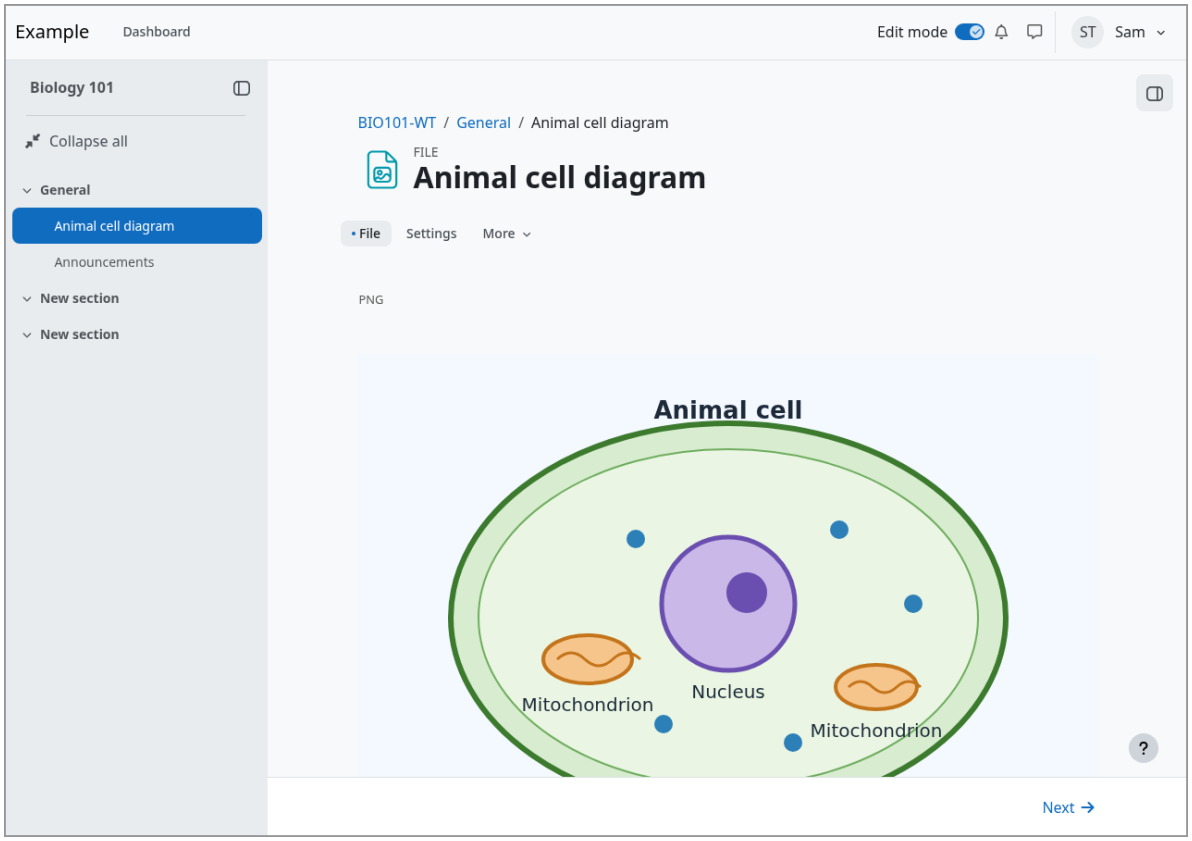
The file is added. Click "Save and return to course".

18 It is in your course

The file now shows on your course page. Click its name to open it, as a student would.



The file on the course page.



What it looks like when opened.

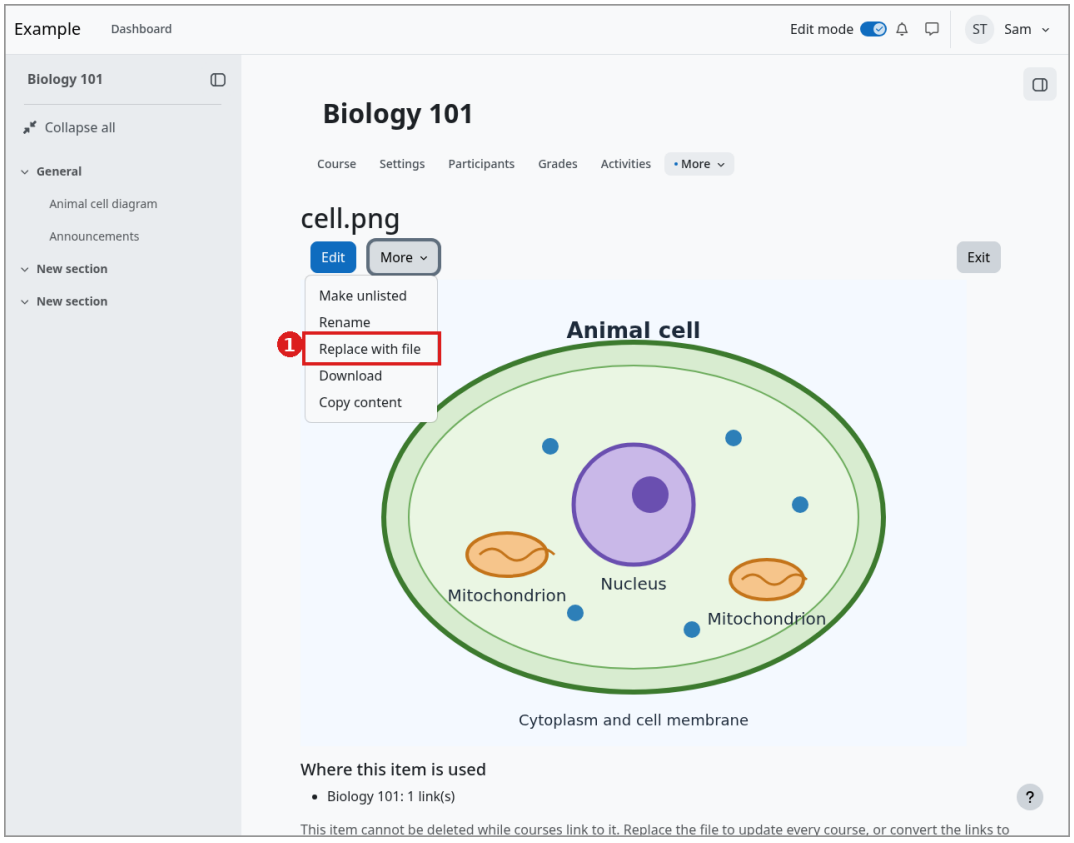
Part 3: Change the file later

Say the picture needs a fix. You change it **once**, in the bank, and every course that **links** to it gets the new picture.

19 Choose "Replace with file"

Click **More**, then click **Replace with file** (red box 1).

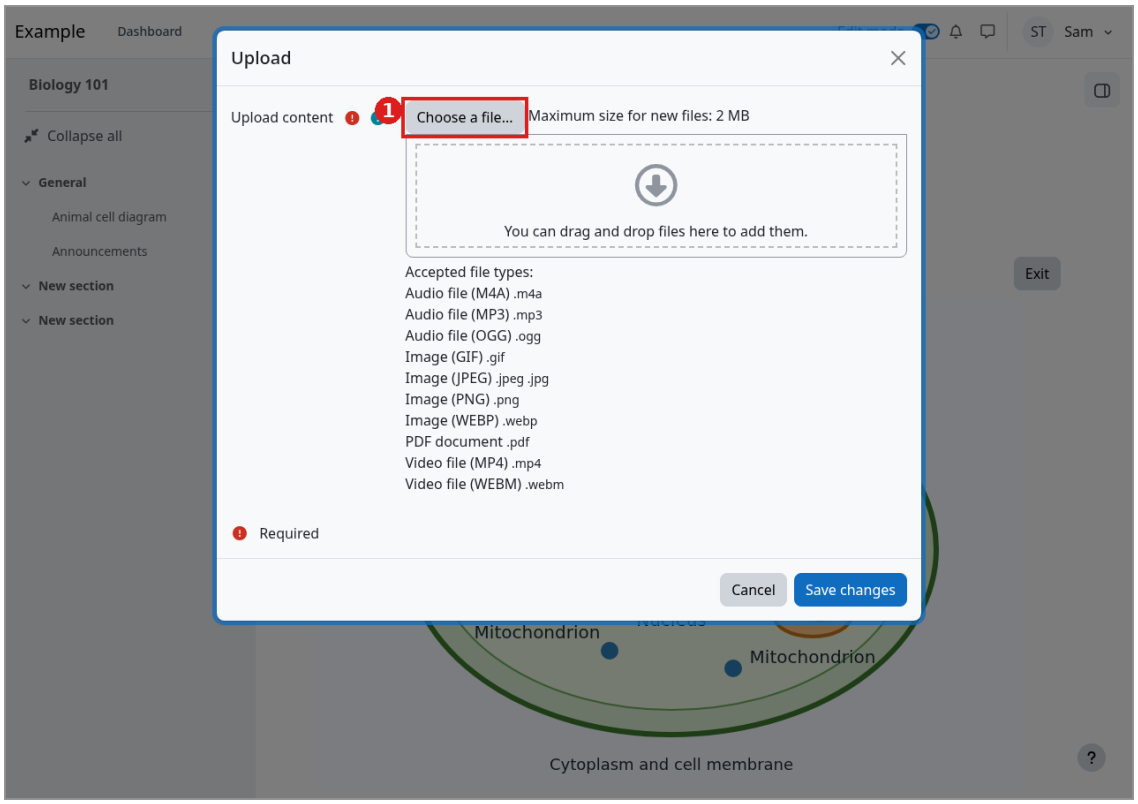
> **Be careful.** The new file must be the **same kind** as the old one. A picture can only be replaced by a picture, a PDF by a PDF, and so on.



The More menu.

20 Pick the new file

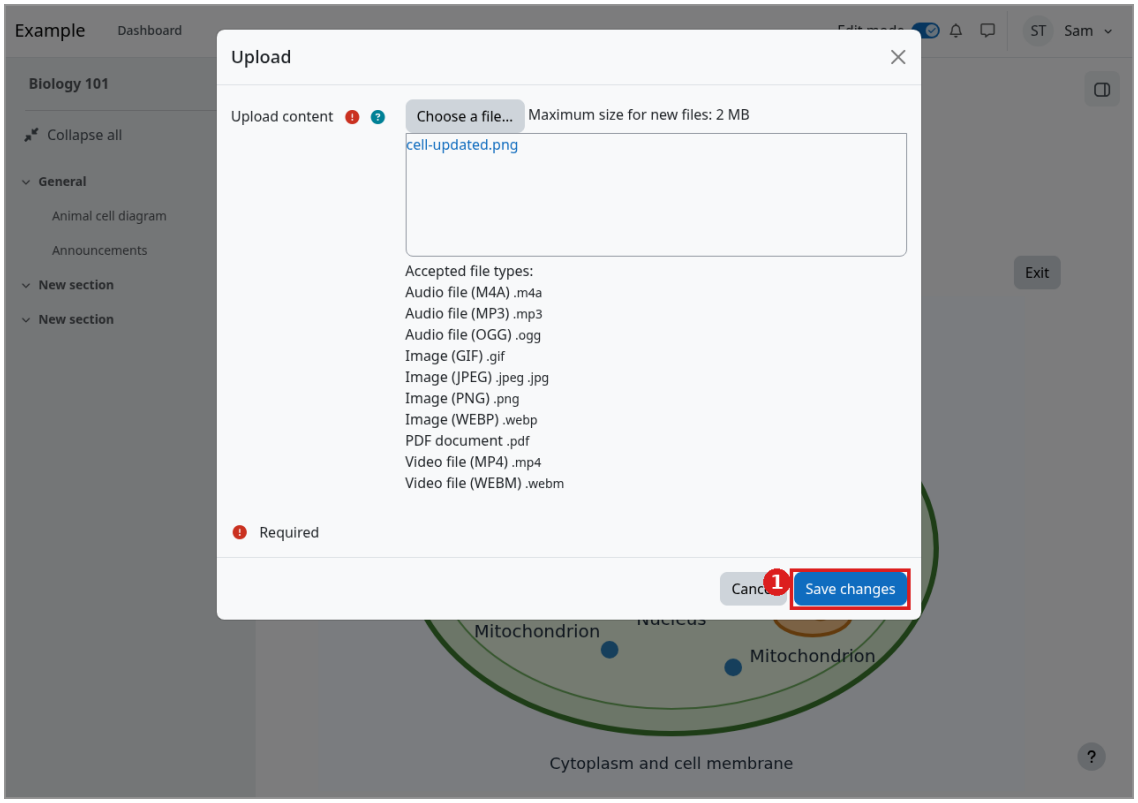
Click **Choose a file...** (red box 1) and pick the new file, exactly as in Part 1 (steps 3 to 5).



The Replace box.

21 Save

When the new file name shows, click **Save changes** (red box 1).

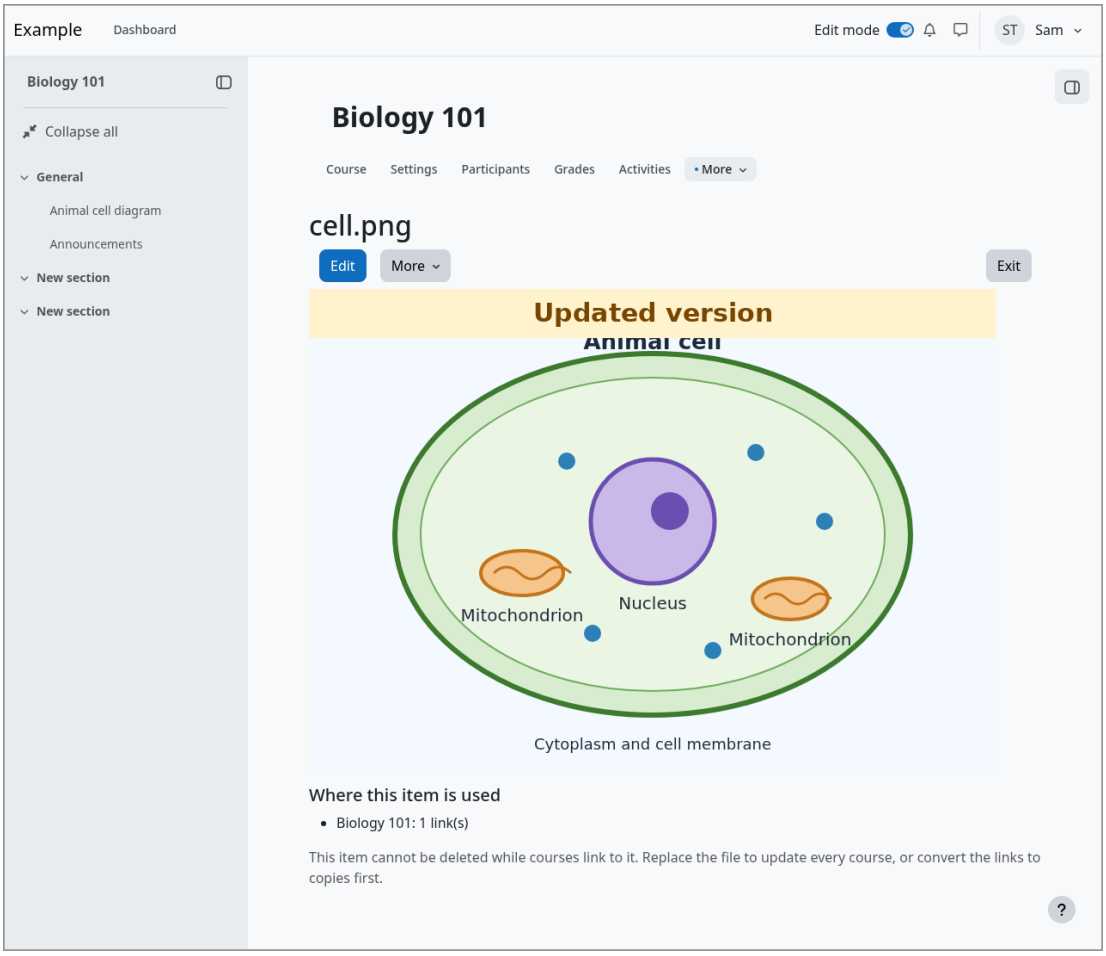


The new file is chosen. Click "Save changes".

22 See what changed and where it is used

Your file page now shows the new picture. Scroll down to **Where this item is used**. It lists the courses that link to the file, for example **Biology 101: 1 link(s)**.

This is normal. You also see the message **"This item cannot be deleted while courses link to it"**. That is on purpose. It protects the courses that use the file.



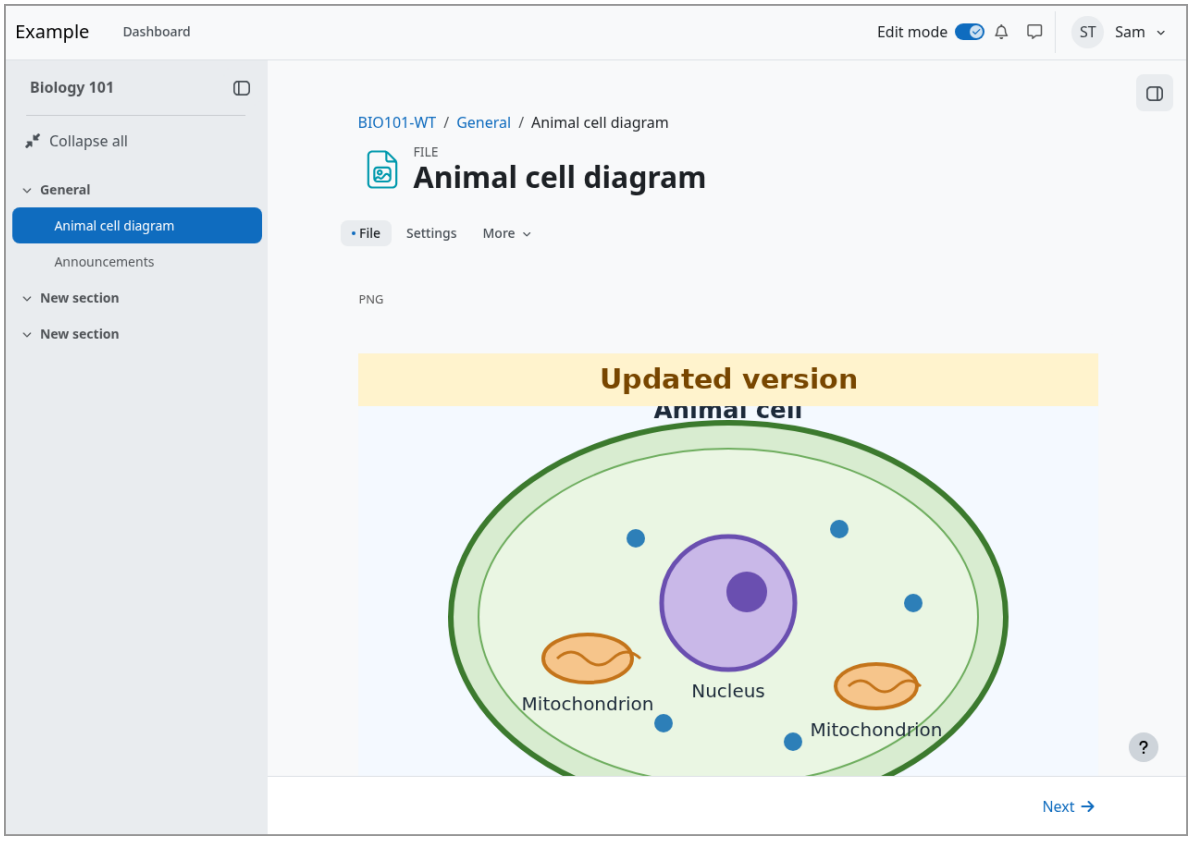
The new picture, and "Where this item is used" under it.

23 The courses have the new file

The page now shows the new picture. Open the course file again: it shows the new picture too.

Tip. If a course still shows the old picture, **refresh the page** (press **Ctrl + F5**, or **Cmd + Shift + R** on a Mac). Your browser may be showing a saved copy.

Be careful. Courses that took a **copy** are **not** changed.



The course now shows the new picture.

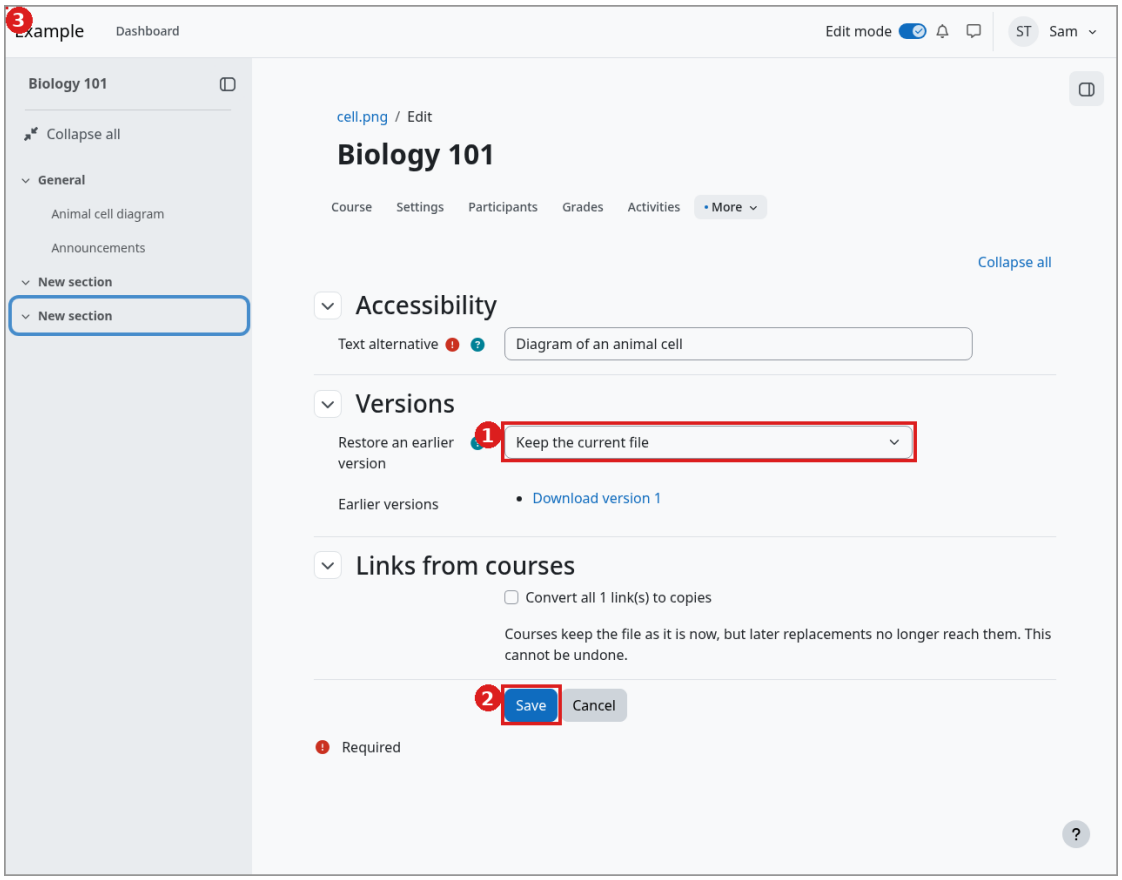
Part 4: Undo a change

Moodle keeps the old file for a while, **30 days** unless your administrator set something else. So you can always go back.

24 Open the Edit page

Open the file and click **Edit**. Under **Versions**, open **Restore an earlier version** (red box 1) and choose the old version. Then click **Save** (red box 2).

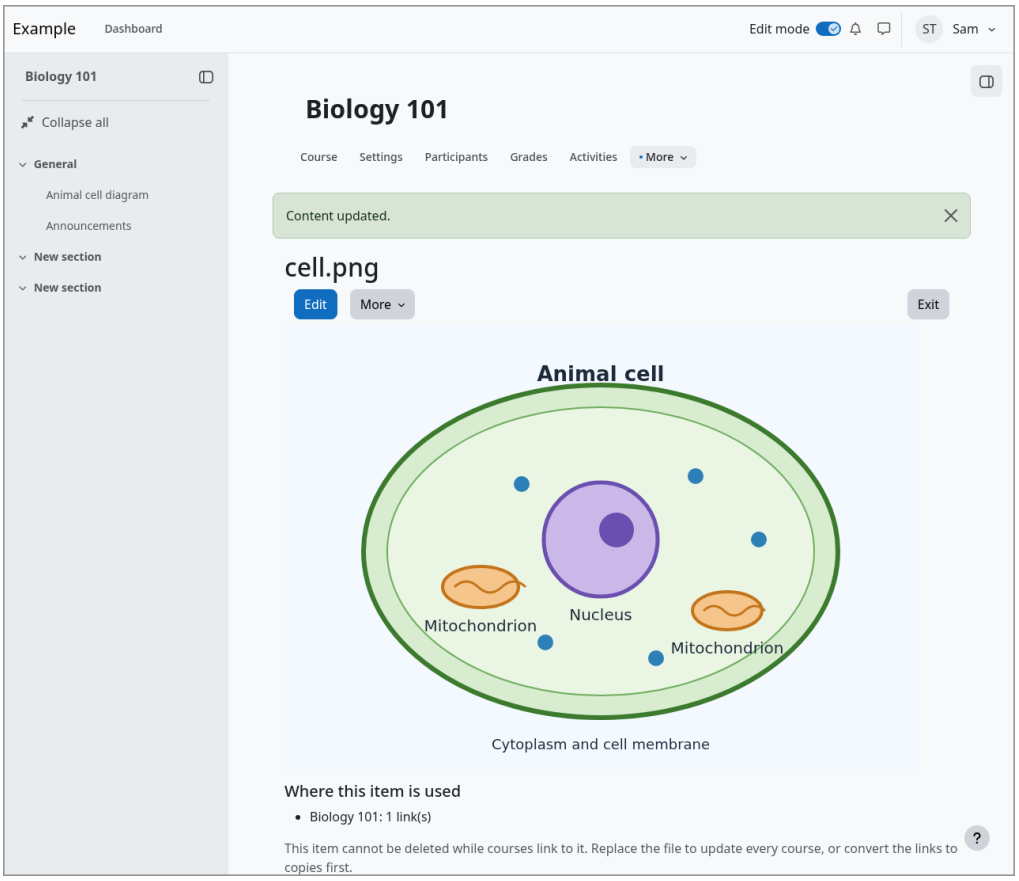
> **Be careful.** Leave **Convert all link(s) to copies** alone (red box 3). Ticking it cannot be undone, and the courses stop following the bank.



The Edit page. Choose the old version and click "Save".

25 The old file is back

You see **Content updated**, and the old picture is back, in every course that links to it. The version you replaced is kept, so you can also undo the undo.



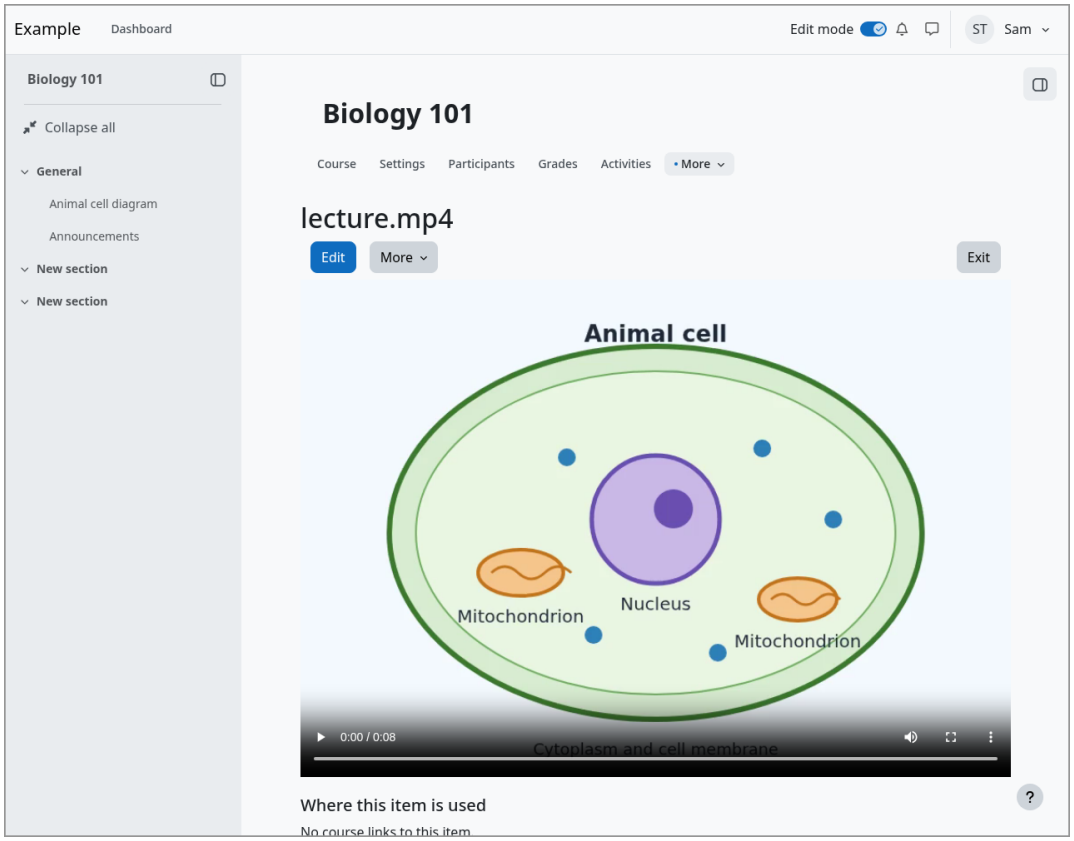
The old picture is back.

Part 5: Videos and audio: add a transcript and captions

People who cannot hear need **captions** or a **transcript**. You can add both to a video or audio file.

26 Open the video

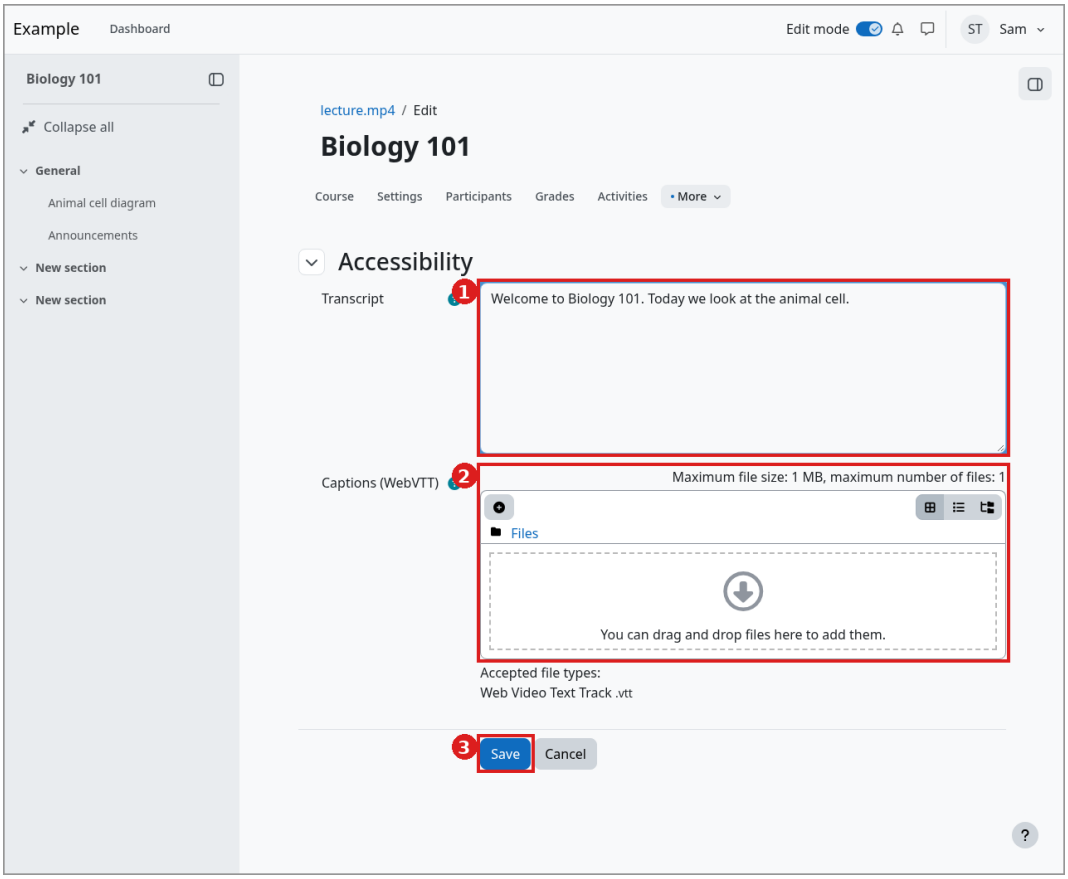
Open the video in the Content bank. You can play it here. Click **Edit**.



A video in the Content bank.

27 Add the words

Type or paste the spoken words in **Transcript** (red box 1). To add captions, click the plus button under **Captions (WebVTT)** (red box 2) and pick a **.vtt** file, in the same way as you picked a file in Part 1. Then click **Save** (red box 3).



The Edit page of a video.

Be careful. Important. The transcript, captions and picture descriptions stay **in the bank**. A course that links to or copies the file gets only the file itself. So also put the transcript on your course page, and make sure a video that needs captions has them **inside the video**.

Tip. PDFs: people who use a screen reader need a **tagged** PDF. Moodle cannot check this for you. Check the PDF before you upload it.

Good to know

Keep a file private

On a file, click **More**, then **Make unlisted**. Other teachers can then no longer see or use it. You can still use it. **Make public** undoes it.

If your file is refused

You see	It means	What to do
"...content is not the kind of file its name says"	It is not really what its name says, for example a document renamed to .png.	Save it again in the right format.
"...this kind of file is not allowed"	Your site does not accept it.	Ask your administrator.
"...larger than the limit of ..."	The file is too big.	Make it smaller, or ask your administrator.
"...is empty"	There is nothing in the file.	Check the original and upload again.
"...an SVG file may contain only a picture..."	The SVG file has something other than a picture in it, or is damaged.	Save it again as a plain SVG, or as a PNG.

A very big file can fail with no message at all. That is a limit on the server. Ask your administrator.

Questions

Can my students see the Content bank? No. They see the file inside your course.

A course still shows the old file. That course took a **copy**. Open its activity, pick the file again, and choose **Link to the file**.

I cannot delete a file. Courses link to it. You can leave it, or ask a manager to convert the links to copies first (Edit page, **Links from courses**). That cannot be undone.

Can I turn just one course's link into a copy? Pick the file again in that activity and choose **Make a copy of the file**.

What if I leave the school? If your account is erased, your bank files go, but courses that used them keep their files as copies.

Who can I ask? Your Moodle administrator. For more detail see the **Teacher guide** and the **FAQ**.

Cheat sheet

I want to…	Do this
Put a file in the bank	Course → **More** → **Content bank** → **Upload** → **Choose a file…** → **Upload a file** → **Choose File** → **Upload this file** → **Save changes**
Describe a picture	Open the picture → **Edit** → **Text alternative** → **Save**
Use a file in my course	Edit mode on → **Add content** → **Activity or resource** → **File** → **Add** → name it → **Add…** → **Content bank** → your file → keep **Link to the file** → **Select this file** → **Save and return to course**
Change a file everywhere	Open it in the bank → **More** → **Replace with file** → pick the new file → **Save changes**
Undo a change	Open it → **Edit** → **Restore an earlier version** → pick one → **Save**
Add a transcript or captions	Open the video or audio → **Edit** → **Transcript** or **Captions (WebVTT)** → **Save**
See which courses use a file	Open it → look at **Where this item is used**
Hide a file from other teachers	Open it → **More** → **Make unlisted**

Remember: Link follows changes. **Copy** never changes. If in doubt, keep **Link**.